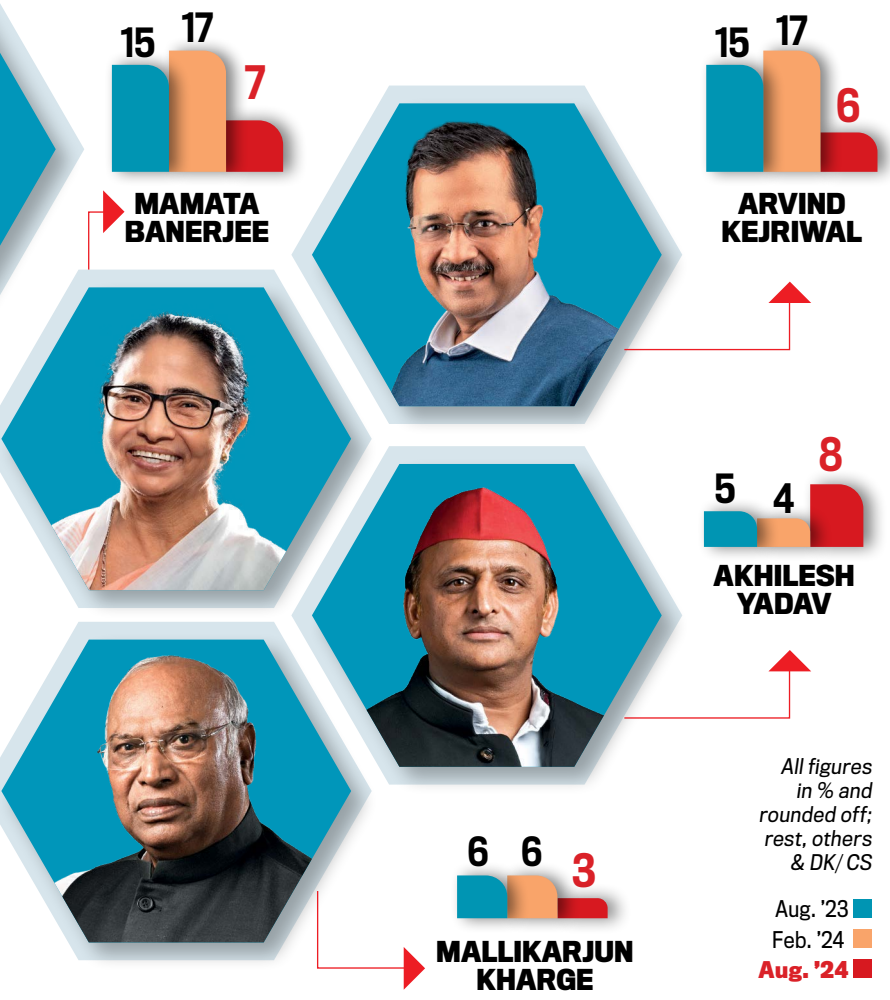
Q. Who among the current leaders is best suited to lead the Opposition alliance?



violence, a statement that quickly drew the ire of his political opponents, who accused him of maligning Hindus. But rather than doubling down on his stance or retreating into silence, Rahul changed tack. Understanding the potential pitfalls of attacking the BJP on its home turf, he shifted his approach, says a senior Congress Lok Sabha MP. The Congress leader, well-versed in Hindu philosophy, invoked the Mahabharata, a cultural touchstone that resonates across India's diverse religious landscape. The move was pure political theatre, but it was also an example of his new strategy, which is carefully calibrated to strike at the government's weak spots without alienating potential supporters.

Behind the scenes, he has become deeply involved in the day-to-day operations of the party. When Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman presented her budget, it was Rahul who personally curated the list of Congress speakers for the ensuing debate. He convened meetings with these MPs, delving into the specifics of the issues they were to raise, ensuring a cohesive narrative that emphasised the party's key themes: defending the Constitution and secularism, advocating for the marginalised, exposing the government's ties to the wealthy and pushing for a caste census.

Rahul's transformation extends beyond the walls of Parliament too. In the first 50 days after the new Parliament was convened, he crisscrossed the country, visiting nine states and engaging with people from all walks of life. From farmers to labourers to students grappling with the leaks in the NEET exams, Rahul has made it a point to lend an ear to the concerns of ordinary Indians and reflect them in the House. This newfound dedication has begun to pay off. In the India Today Mood of the Nation poll, when asked to evaluate Rahul Gandhi's performance as Leader of the Opposition, 51.2 per cent of the respondents rated his performance as either outstanding or good, indicating a favourable perception among more than half of the electorate.

THE TOP CHALLENGER

The poll also indicates that he has consolidated his position as the top challenger to Prime Minister Modi. The Gandhi sibling is rated as the best suited to lead the Opposition alliance against the ruling BJP with 32.3 per cent respondents backing him, a significant rise from 21.3 per cent in February 2024 and 23.6 per cent in August 2023. This surge indicates growing confidence in Rahul's leadership among the electorate, possibly influenced by his increased visibility and assertiveness in recent months.

However, his lead also highlights the fragmented nature of the Opposition, with other potential leaders like West Bengal chief minister and Trinamool Congress leader Mamata Banerjee and Delhi Chief Minister and Aam Aadmi Party leader Arvind Kejriwal witnessing a sharp decline in support. Mamata's backing plummeted to 7.2 per cent from 16.5 per cent in February, while Kejriwal dropped to 6.2 per cent